

From intuition to knowledge: the scientific consolidation of management consulting

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Abstract

Purpose – The purpose of this paper is to examine the evolution of management consulting from an experience-based professional practice to an increasingly consolidated scientific field. By systematically reviewing the academic literature, the study aims to identify the main conceptual foundations, influential authors, thematic trends, and emerging research streams that have shaped the development of management consulting over time. In doing so, the paper seeks to contribute to a clearer understanding of the discipline's intellectual structure and its ongoing process of academic institutionalization.

Design/methodology/approach – The study adopts a systematic literature review combined with bibliometric analysis. Following the PRISMA guidelines, relevant publications were identified, screened, and selected from the Scopus database. A final sample of 136 articles published between 1980 and 2025 was analyzed using Biblioshiny within the R environment. Descriptive and relational bibliometric techniques were applied to examine publication trends, authorship patterns, sources, geographical distribution, and thematic networks, allowing for a comprehensive mapping of the field's intellectual landscape.

Findings – This study adopts a systematic literature review combined with bibliometric analysis. Following the PRISMA guidelines, relevant publications were identified, screened, and selected from the Scopus database. A final sample of 136 articles published between 1980 and 2025 was analyzed using Biblioshiny within the R environment. Descriptive and relational bibliometric techniques were applied to examine publication trends, authorship patterns, sources, geographical distribution, and thematic networks, allowing for a comprehensive mapping of the field's intellectual landscape.

Research limitations/implications – This study is subject to limitations inherent to bibliometric and systematic review approaches. First, the analysis is based exclusively on the Scopus database, which may exclude relevant publications indexed elsewhere. Second, the findings rely on bibliometric indicators and thematic co-occurrence, which capture structural patterns but do not assess the substantive quality or causal impact of individual studies. Despite these limitations, the results provide a robust foundation for future research, particularly empirical and qualitative studies aimed at deepening the understanding of knowledge production and value creation in management consulting.

Practical implications – The findings offer practical insights for consultants, consulting firms, and organizational decision-makers. By identifying dominant themes and emerging research streams, the study helps practitioners understand how management consulting is evolving toward digital, knowledge-intensive, and sustainability-oriented practices. Consulting firms may use these insights to align capability development, talent profiles, and service portfolios with contemporary demands. Additionally, the results can inform professional training programs by highlighting the growing importance of digital competencies, interdisciplinary knowledge, and reflective practice in consulting work.

Social implications – From a social perspective, this study highlights the role of management consulting as a mechanism for knowledge diffusion and organizational learning within increasingly complex and digitalized societies. By supporting more informed decision making, consulting practices can contribute to organizational adaptability, responsible innovation and sustainable development. The growing emphasis on digital transformation and knowledge management also underscores the need for inclusive skill development and

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ethical awareness ensuring that consulting-driven transformations generate broader societal value beyond purely economic outcomes.

Originality/value – This study provides an integrative and up-to-date overview of the management consulting literature by combining a systematic review with bibliometric mapping techniques. By revealing the intellectual structure and thematic evolution of the field, this paper offers original insights into the scientific consolidation of management consulting. The findings contribute to both scholars and practitioners by clarifying dominant research streams, identifying underexplored areas, and highlighting opportunities for future research in an increasingly digital and knowledge-intensive consulting landscape.

Keywords Management consulting, Strategic management, Systematic literature review, Professionalization, Digital transformation

Paper type Literature review

Introduction

Management consulting, as it is understood today, is the result of a process of institutionalization that gradually took shape throughout the twentieth century. [Kubr \(2002\)](#) emphasizes that the profession consolidated around principles that go beyond the mere provision of expert advice: consultant independence, methodological rigor, ethical conduct, and the ability to facilitate organizational learning became core pillars that redefined the consultant's role and expanded their contribution within organizations. Consequently, the traditional figure of the “external expert” gave way to a professional who accompanies change processes and promotes the dynamics of collective reflection.

In this context, organizations no longer seek sole technical solutions or standardized answers. Increasingly, they demand the ability to understand environmental complexity, integrate strategic perspectives, and foster sustainable transformations ([Werr & Styhre, 2002](#); [Fincham, 2012](#)). This shift is also reflected in the field's scientific output: since the early twenty-first century, publications on consulting have grown steadily, driven by the globalization of professional services, digitalization, and the need for more flexible responses to highly dynamic environments ([Werr & Stjernberg, 2003](#); [Alvesson, 2019](#)).

In parallel, the contemporary consultant increasingly resembles the figure of the “reflective practitioner” described by [Schön \(1983\)](#). This perspective emphasizes the importance of combining technical knowledge with practical judgment, particularly when confronting unique, uncertain, or ambiguous situations that are common in contemporary organizational management. Consulting, understood from this standpoint, is not merely a transfer of knowledge but a situated practice that requires interpreting contexts, building relationships of trust, and fostering learning processes.

In the past decade, digital acceleration has introduced a new turning point in this evolutionary process. The emergence of hybrid profiles, such as the business-techno consultant, illustrates how the integration of management and technology has ceased to be optional and has instead become a core professional competence ([Mukerjee, Acharya, Stl, & Ghosh, 2023](#)). These professionals combine strategic capabilities with a deep understanding of emerging technologies, enabling them to act as intermediaries between business vision and the adoption of digital solutions.

Taken together, these transformations call for a reassessment of how management consulting has evolved both as a professional practice and as a field of academic inquiry. The objective of this article is to provide a systematized overview of this trajectory by identifying its key conceptual milestones, the most influential authors, emerging research trends, and the challenges that continue to hinder its consolidation as a scientific discipline.

Despite the growing body of literature on management consulting, existing studies remain fragmented across disciplines and are often limited either to descriptive accounts of professional practice or to narrowly scoped bibliometric analyses focused on specific periods or subthemes. In particular, prior reviews tend to privilege short temporal windows, single conceptual lenses, or purely quantitative mappings, offering limited insight into the long-term epistemological consolidation of consulting as a field of knowledge.

This study addresses these limitations by providing a comprehensive longitudinal analysis of management consulting research spanning more than four decades (1983–2025), integrating a systematic review based on PRISMA guidelines with a bibliometric and interpretative analysis. By combining quantitative mapping with qualitative synthesis, the article goes beyond descriptive metrics to examine how management consulting has evolved as an institutionalized knowledge system, shaped by processes of professionalization, digital transformation, and changing consultant - client relationships. In doing so, the study contributes a holistic perspective that not only consolidates existing research streams but also clarifies emerging trajectories and unresolved tensions within the field.

Methodology

Methodological approach

The study was conducted following the PRISMA (Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Reviews and Meta-Analyses) methodology, a widely recognized standard for ensuring transparency in the processes of searching, selecting, and synthesizing scientific literature. This choice responds to the need to ensure traceability at each stage of the analysis and to apply replicable criteria that allow the consistency of the study to be assessed.

The procedure was complemented by a descriptive and relational bibliometric analysis, carried out using the Biblioshiny software integrated into the *R* statistical environment (version 4.2). Scopus was used as the primary source for document retrieval due to its broad thematic coverage and its inclusion of high-impact journals in the fields of management and professional services.

Data collection and screening process

The initial search in Scopus was conducted using the following query string:

TITLE-ABS-KEY (business AND consulting) AND (LIMIT-TO(EXACTKEYWORD, “Consulting”)). As a result of the screening and eligibility phases, a final sample of 136 documents published between 1983 and 2025 was identified. In addition, three external sources from specialized academic repositories were incorporated in order to strengthen the conceptual perspective of the analysis. The selection process followed the four phases established by PRISMA - identification, screening, eligibility, and final inclusion - the steps of which are summarized in the diagram presented in [Figure 1](#).

Variables and indicators analyzed

The bibliometric analysis covered a set of variables characteristic of scientific production in management consulting. The variables considered included:

- (1) Year of publication
- (2) Authors and co-authorships
- (3) Institutional affiliation
- (4) Country of origin
- (5) Journals and academic sources
- (6) Keywords
- (7) Number of citations
- (8) Co-authorship networks and thematic co-occurrence

To assess scholarly impact, indicators such as the h-index, total citation counts per author, and the frequency of key concept occurrences were employed. This set of metrics made it possible to examine the intellectual structure of the field and to identify patterns of evolution over time.

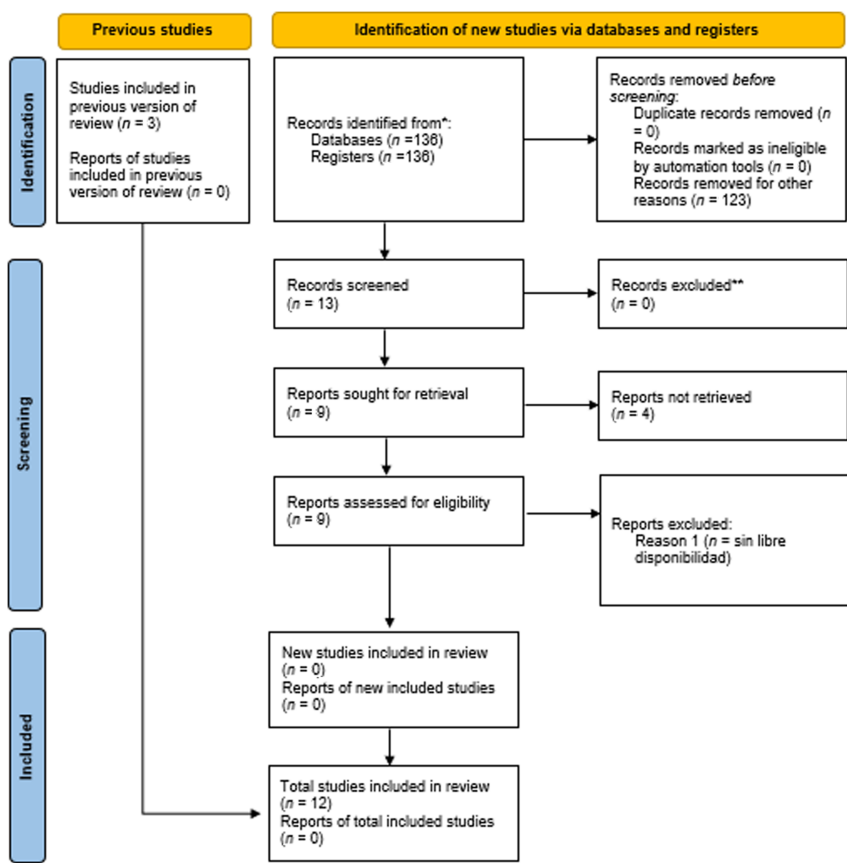


Figure 1. PRISMA process followed in this study. *Note.* Adapted from “The PRISMA 2020 statement: an updated guideline for reporting systematic reviews,” by Page (2021), *BMJ*, 71, p. 19

General characterization of the sample

The 136 documents included exhibit an average annual growth rate of 4.36%. The overall dataset comprises 419 authors, with an average of 4.88 co-authors per article, suggesting that management consulting is a collaborative and multidisciplinary field. However, international co-authorship accounts for only 7.3% of the publications, indicating a limited globalization of the knowledge produced.

The identified literature is distributed across 103 sources and includes 549 distinct keywords, indicating that the field is undergoing a process of conceptual diversification. On average, the articles have an age of approximately ten years and register a global impact of 8.27 citations per document, confirming a growing academic interest that is still in the process of consolidation within the management sciences.

Temporal, geographical, and institutional distribution

The descriptive analysis of the database reveals a sustained temporal evolution since 2000, with a peak in scientific output in 2019 and a slight stabilization between 2020 and 2024 (see Figure 2). At the authorship level, Pereira stands out with four publications, followed by von Ameln with three. Regarding institutional affiliation, the most prominent institutions include the ISCTE Instituto Universitário de Lisboa, the National Bureau of Economic Research, and the University of Münster (see Figure 3).

From a geographical perspective, the United States leads scientific production with more than fifty documents, followed by Germany, France, the United Kingdom, and Portugal. This pattern confirms a concentration of knowledge production in countries of the Global North, although emerging contributions are beginning to appear in Brazil, Ukraine, and Canada (see Figure 4).

Documents by year

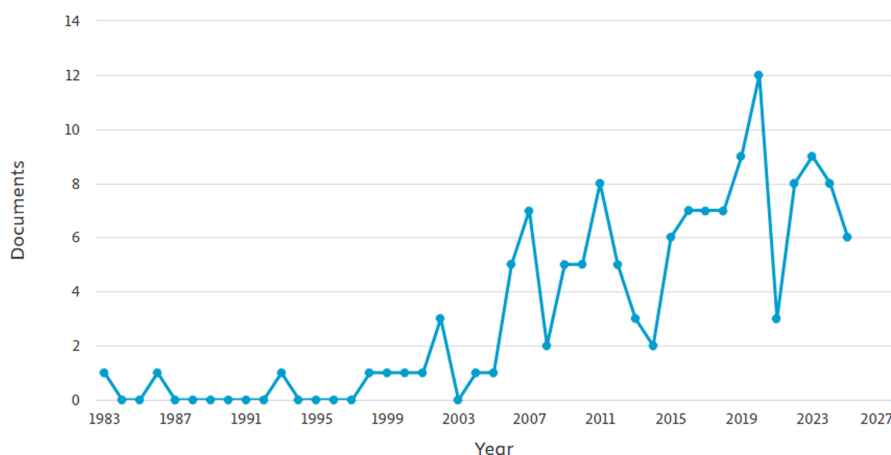


Figure 2. Temporal evolution of scientific output. *Note.* Adapted from Scopus statistical analysis

Compare the document counts for up to 15 authors.

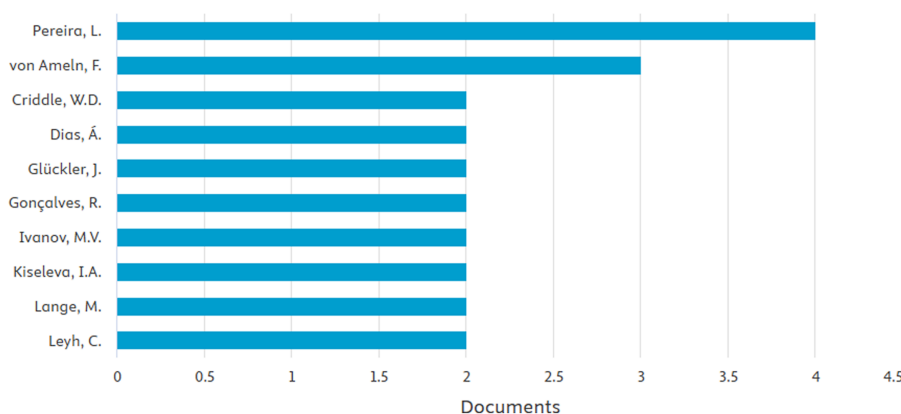


Figure 3. Documents by author. *Note.* Adapted from Scopus statistical analysis

Documents by country or territory
Compare the document counts for up to 15 countries/territories.

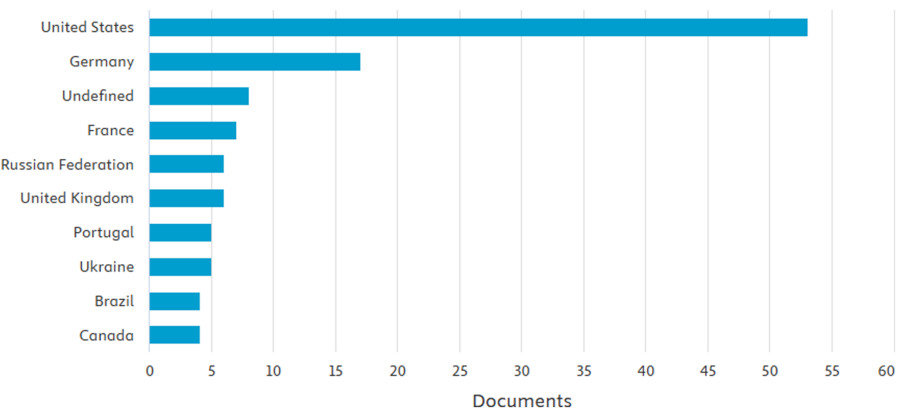


Figure 4. Geographical distribution of publications by country. *Note.* Adapted from Scopus statistical analysis

Methodological synthesis

Overall, the methodology employed makes it possible to characterize the evolution of the management consulting field from a rigorous and comparative perspective. The combined use of PRISMA and bibliometric analysis provides a solid foundation for understanding both the historical trajectory of the field and its emerging trends, thereby offering a valuable input for the critical analysis developed in the following sections.

Inclusion and exclusion criteria

To ensure the relevance, consistency, and replicability of the review, explicit inclusion and exclusion criteria were applied throughout the screening process. Studies were included when management consulting or business consulting constituted the central analytical focus of the article, rather than being treated as a secondary or illustrative concept. Only peer-reviewed journal articles were considered, in order to guarantee academic rigor and quality control. The temporal scope was limited to publications released between 1983 and 2025, a period that captures both the early stages of the institutionalization of consulting research and its more recent transformation under conditions of digitalization. In addition, only articles written in English were included to allow for consistent analysis and comparability across studies. Finally, all selected documents were required to be indexed in the Scopus database, which was chosen for its extensive coverage of high-impact journals in the fields of management, business, and professional services.

Conversely, studies were excluded when they focused exclusively on consulting in a narrow technical or operational sense, such as IT outsourcing or software implementation, without engaging in consulting as a professional, organizational, or knowledge-based practice. Documents that were not subject to peer review, including conference papers, editorials, book reviews, and practitioner-oriented reports, were also excluded. Articles in which consulting was mentioned only tangentially and did not substantively contribute to the understanding of consulting processes, roles, or outcomes were not retained. Duplicate records identified during the screening process were likewise removed.

In addition to the core bibliometric sample, a limited number of external academic sources were consulted to enrich the conceptual discussion and contextual interpretation of the findings. These sources were not incorporated into the bibliometric dataset and therefore did

not influence the quantitative results; instead, they were used exclusively to support theoretical reflection and the development of the discussion.

Justification for the use of scopus as the primary database

Scopus was selected as the sole database for document retrieval due to its broad and multidisciplinary coverage of peer-reviewed journals in the fields of management, business, and professional services, as well as its recognized reliability for bibliometric research.

Compared with alternative databases, Scopus offers broader journal coverage, standardized metadata, and robust citation tracking, which are essential for conducting longitudinal and relational bibliometric analyses, particularly in the social sciences and management fields (Mongeon & Paul-Hus, 2016; Donthu, Kumar, Mukherjee, Pandey, & Lim, 2021). Its comprehensive coverage of high-impact international journals ensures consistency in data extraction and minimizes duplication across sources, thereby enhancing the transparency and replicability of the review process.

While reliance on a single database may limit the inclusion of certain regional or non-indexed publications, this choice reflects a deliberate methodological trade-off aimed at ensuring data quality, comparability, and analytical coherence. This approach is consistent with established practices in bibliometric research and supports the study's objective of mapping the scientific consolidation of management consulting within the core body of internationally visible academic literature.

Results

Temporal evolution of scientific output

The analysis of records retrieved from Scopus shows a trajectory of progressive growth in research on management consulting between 1983 and 2025. During the first two decades, scientific output was sporadic, with an annual average of fewer than two publications, suggesting that the field had not yet been fully established as a distinct area of study. From 2004 onward, a sustained increase can be observed, reaching a peak in 2019 with twelve articles. In subsequent years, the trend stabilizes, remaining above pre-2010 levels, which indicates a consolidated level of interest from the academic community.

This evolution allows for the identification of three broad phases. The first phase, spanning 1983 to 2003, corresponds to an incipient period characterized by limited output. The second phase, from 2004 to 2015, reflects a process of methodological expansion and professionalization of the field. The third phase, covering 2016 to 2025, is characterized by greater scientific consolidation and the incorporation of themes related to digitalization and organizational innovation.

Most productive authors and sources

With regard to authorship, the data indicate that Pereira and von Ameln are the most productive contemporary researchers in the field, with four and three publications, respectively. These contributions coexist with a set of classical works, particularly those of Kubr (2002) and Werr and Styhre (2002), which continue to exert a significant influence on recent literature. The combination of emerging authors and established references suggests that the field maintains an active dialogue between its conceptual foundations and the new dynamics derived from digital transformation.

Geographical and institutional distribution

Scientific output exhibits clear geographical concentration. The United States leads with more than fifty publications, followed by Germany, France, the United Kingdom, and Portugal. This distribution reflects the predominance of institutions from the Global North in the production of knowledge on management consulting. Nevertheless, increasing contributions from Brazil,

Ukraine, and Canada are beginning to emerge, which may anticipate a gradual diversification of the field.

At the institutional level, ISCTE Instituto Universitário de Lisboa, the National Bureau of Economic Research, and the University of Münster stand out. These institutions have developed consistent research streams that link management consulting with themes such as knowledge management, innovation, and organizational systems.

Co-authorship networks and keyword analysis

The analysis of keyword co-occurrence reveals a significant thematic evolution. From the year 2000 onward, concepts such as business, consulting, management, and research have increased in prominence in parallel, indicating a growing integration between applied research and consulting practice. Since 2015, this dynamic has intensified with the emergence of terms associated with digital consulting, organizational transformation, and technological innovation, a pattern consistent with the rise of so-called Consulting 4.0.

The semantic analysis identified three main conceptual clusters. The first focuses on the relationship between consulting and organizational knowledge, with an emphasis on knowledge management, learning, and innovation. The second group relates to themes associated with digitalization, technology adoption, and artificial intelligence applied to business advisory services. The third is linked to corporate sustainability, ethics, and organizational change, reflecting the growing relevance of responsible practices within the sector (see [Figures 5 and 6](#)).

Overall, the results show that management consulting has developed an increasingly robust academic corpus, with clearly defined thematic lines and a conceptual structure that is in the process of consolidation. The prominence and accelerated growth of digitalization-related terms in the longitudinal analysis, together with recent scholarly contributions (e.g. [Brazo, Velicia-Martín, Palos-Sanchez, & Rodrigues, 2023](#); [Mukerjee et al., 2023](#)), suggest that digital transformation increasingly shapes both research agendas and professional practice in management consulting. The identified evolution suggests that the discipline is entering a stage of growing maturity, with the capacity to integrate traditional approaches and new perspectives driven by technological and institutional change.

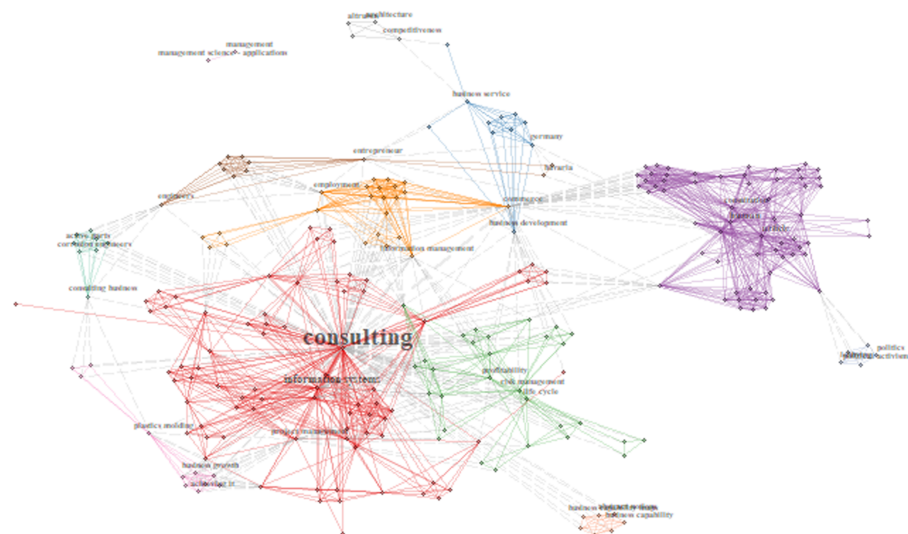


Figure 5. Keyword co-occurrence. *Note.* Derived from the bibliometric analysis using Biblioshiny

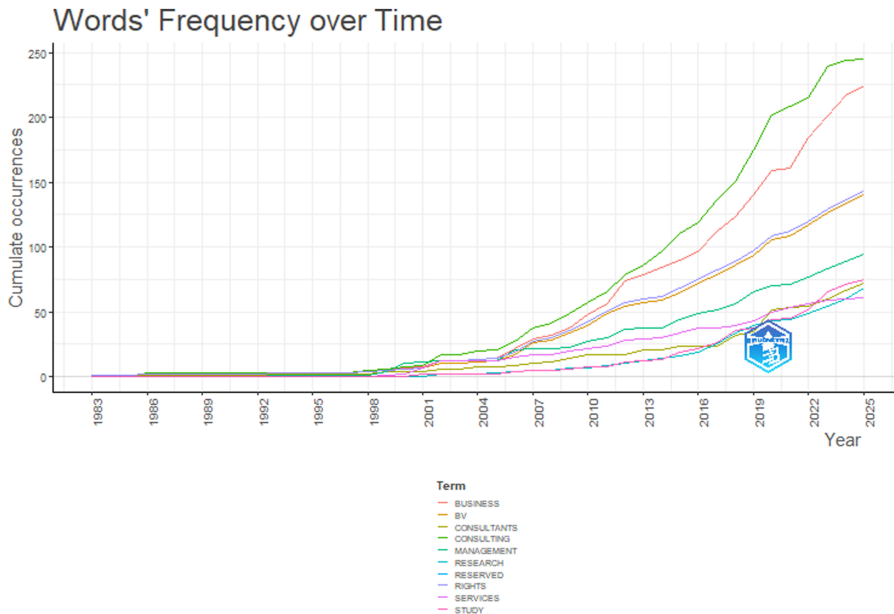


Figure 6. Keyword frequency (1983–2025). *Note.* Derived from the bibliometric analysis using Biblioshiny

Analysis of thematic axes in management consulting research

Thematic map (Figure 7) provides a strategic representation of the main conceptual cores that structure the field of management consulting. This type of visualization, generated using the bibliometric tool Biblioshiny, allows themes to be classified according to two dimensions.

- (1) The degree of development or density, which measures how consolidated or specialized a theme is within its own domain; and
- (2) The degree of relevance or centrality, which indicates how strongly the theme is connected to others within the global knowledge system.

The intersection of these two dimensions results in four quadrants, each with a specific meaning in terms of the role that themes play within the scientific ecosystem.

Motor themes. Located in the upper-right quadrant, motor themes display high density and high centrality. They represent the most well-articulated and influential conceptual axes within the field. The map highlights consulting, information systems, and project management, indicating that contemporary research in management consulting is oriented toward the integration of advisory services, project management, and information systems.

These topics reflect the maturity and dynamism of the field, where consulting is understood as a structured process of knowledge transfer supported by digital tools and advanced management methodologies. They constitute the pillars that currently define both professional practice and academic research in consulting, underscoring its strategic role in organizational transformation.

The positioning of consulting, information systems, and project management as motor themes suggests that the scientific consolidation of the field is increasingly anchored in technologically mediated organizational change processes. Rather than remaining confined to advisory rhetoric, management consulting research appears to converge around structured intervention logics supported by digital infrastructures and formalized project governance mechanisms. This indicates a shift from an experience-driven practice toward a systematized and methodologically grounded discipline.

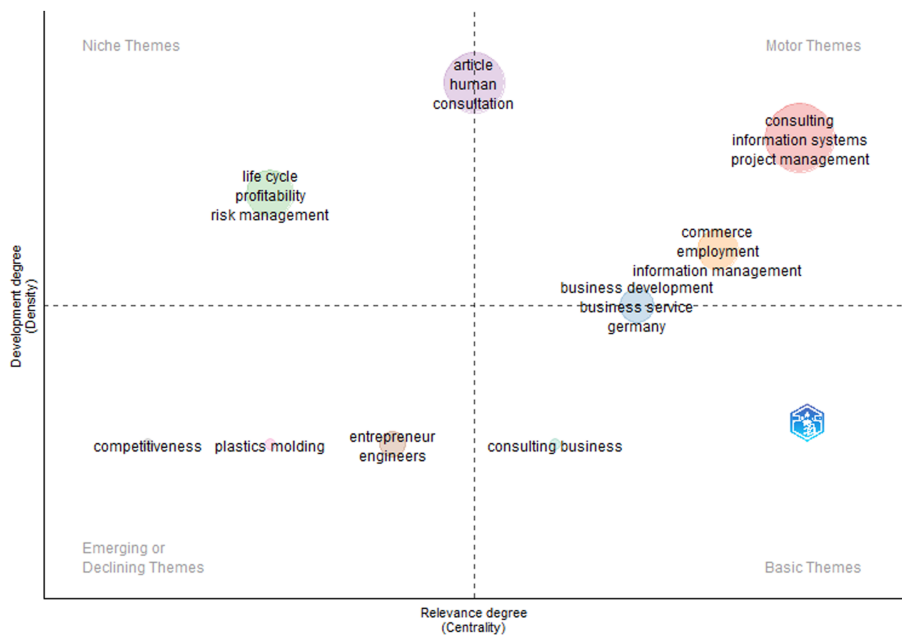


Figure 7. Thematic map. *Note.* Derived from the bibliometric analysis using *Biblioshiny*

Basic or transversal themes. The lower-right quadrant groups themes characterized by high centrality and low density, that is, areas that are conceptually important but still in the process of further development. These include commerce, employment, information management, business development, business services, and Germany.

The presence of “Germany” within this quadrant does not represent a thematic construct per se, but rather reflects a strong national concentration of scholarly output and citation linkages within the dataset. In bibliometric mapping, geographical identifiers may emerge as structural nodes when a country exhibits sustained productivity and interconnected research activity.

These concepts function as structural foundations of knowledge in management consulting, being closely linked to service development, information management, employment, and commercial dynamics. Although they have not yet reached a high level of specialization, they represent transversal themes that sustain the conceptual architecture of the field and are likely to continue expanding as the discipline evolves toward more global and interdisciplinary approaches.

Niche themes. The upper-left quadrant comprises themes characterized by high density and low centrality, that is, areas that are highly developed internally but have limited connections with the broader theoretical system. Prominent among these are life cycle, profitability, and risk management, together with a smaller group including article, human, and consultation.

These topics represent specialized or methodological subfields, particularly those focused on project life-cycle assessment, profitability analysis, and risk management within consulting processes. The appearance of more generic descriptors such as “article” and “human” does not necessarily indicate coherent theoretical constructs; rather, they may reflect indexing patterns or methodological clustering within specific research sub-communities. Their limited centrality suggests that, although technically developed, these streams remain weakly integrated into the dominant theoretical architecture of management consulting research.

This configuration indicates that certain analytical and practice-oriented domains evolve with substantial internal sophistication but limited cross-fertilization with broader conceptual debates. While such niches strengthen the technical and evaluative dimensions of consulting, they also reveal a partial fragmentation within the field, characteristic of disciplines undergoing progressive consolidation.

Emerging or declining themes. The lower-left quadrant groups themes characterized by low density and low centrality, which are typically interpreted as peripheral within the current research landscape. Concepts such as competitiveness, plastics molding, entrepreneurs, engineers, and consulting business appear in this area.

Rather than representing consolidated theoretical streams, these themes reflect either exploratory trajectories that have not yet achieved structural integration into the core of management consulting research or residual application-specific domains with limited cross-disciplinary diffusion. When interpreted alongside the temporal growth patterns identified earlier, these clusters are more plausibly understood as context-bound or emergent research niches rather than formerly central paradigms in decline. Some may indeed represent diminishing areas of interest, while others may signal early developments linked to the intersection of consulting with entrepreneurship, industrial applications, or applied engineering contexts. A more granular temporal analysis would be required to distinguish clearly between declining trajectories and expanding thematic fronts.

Taken together, the configuration of the four quadrants indicates that management consulting has reached a notable level of theoretical differentiation and structural maturity. Consolidated research streams coexist with transversal conceptual foundations, specialized methodological domains, and peripheral exploratory areas.

Motor themes, such as consulting, project management, and information systems, form the dynamic core of knowledge in the field, while basic themes, such as information management, business development, and employment, act as platforms for interdisciplinary expansion. Niche themes contribute to methodological depth, and peripheral themes reflect the field's adaptive capacity and openness to contextual innovation.

Overall, the thematic map demonstrates that management consulting has evolved from a predominantly practice-driven and experience-based activity toward a structured and differentiated knowledge system. Innovation, information management, and digital transformation increasingly function as organizing principles that shape both academic inquiry and professional practice within the discipline.

Consulting in the context of digitalization and institutional pressure

In this study, a conceptual distinction is maintained between digitalization and digital transformation. Digitalization refers to the integration of digital technologies into existing organizational processes in order to enhance efficiency and operational performance (Brazo *et al.*, 2023; Wattiez & Goy, 2023). By contrast, digital transformation denotes a broader strategic and structural reconfiguration involving changes in business models, governance arrangements, and value creation logics (Mukerjee *et al.*, 2023). This distinction is analytically relevant for understanding how consulting firms move from incremental technological adoption to deeper transformations in their organizational and value-creation architectures.

The sustained growth of digitalization-related terms in the longitudinal keyword analysis indicates the increasing centrality of digital transformation within the intellectual structure of management consulting research. This bibliometric evidence suggests a structural reorientation of the field toward digitally mediated advisory practices. Such a trend is consistent with Brazo *et al.* (2023), who argue that digital transformation has significantly altered organizational processes and reshaped how value is created and delivered within consulting firms. According to these authors, consulting firms function as key intermediaries in the transfer and adoption of digital technologies, particularly in contexts where client organizations lack sufficient internal resources to implement digital transformation independently.

Institutional pressure, such as mandatory government regulations (e.g. electronic invoicing), can act as a driver of business digitalization (Brazo *et al.*, 2023). This pressure compels small firms in particular to seek support from consultants to facilitate the adoption and implementation of digital processes that were previously analog (Brazo *et al.*, 2023). When consulting services channel this process, outcomes, both in terms of digitalization and business performance, are strengthened (Brazo *et al.*, 2023). In this sense, the consultant's role is regarded as a catalyst with a direct effect on a firm's digitalization (Brazo *et al.*, 2023).

Recent scholarship further suggests that the transformation of consulting under digital pressure is not merely technological, but institutional and organizational in nature. Emerging perspectives emphasize the role of consultants as boundary-spanners who contribute to organizational resilience and adaptive capacity in increasingly uncertain environments (Hrebeshkova, Kyzenko, & Verba, 2025).

The emergence of the business-techno consultant

Modern consulting requires a multidisciplinary approach (Mukerjee *et al.*, 2023). Demand for "Business-Techno [IT]" consultants is rapidly increasing, as these professionals help firms overcome both external and internal shocks, such as digitalization (Mukerjee *et al.*, 2023).

The traditional management consultant is increasingly operating one or two levels closer to tactical execution rather than remaining confined to purely strategic advisory roles, with information technology playing a central enabling function (Mukerjee *et al.*, 2023). In this context, the consultant's cognitive focus shifts toward assessing the tangible value that organizations ultimately derive from technological investments, translating strategic intent into measurable business outcomes (Mukerjee *et al.*, 2023). This role reconfiguration is reinforced by market projections reported by Mukerjee *et al.* (2023), which indicate sustained expansion of the Business-Techno/IT consulting segment, which is expected to grow at a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 7.62% between 2021 and 2025.

Transformation of client - consultant relationships

The conceptualization of the client-consultant relationship has evolved over time, influenced by dominant management discourses (Werr & Styhre, 2002). The literature identifies two main discursive frameworks that explain this evolution.

Early normative conceptions of consulting were largely grounded in a traditional bureaucratic discourse. Within this framework, consulting is understood as a contractual, distant, and temporary service focused on solving clearly defined tasks. The client assumes a controlling role as the rational "buyer" who hires an external expert to deliver predefined solutions (Werr & Styhre, 2002). This perspective emphasizes formality, control, and clear boundaries between the consultant and the client organization.

In contrast, contemporary consulting practice, particularly within the context of the knowledge economy, aligns more closely with a network discourse that emphasizes collaboration and continuous change (Werr & Styhre, 2002). Under this perspective, consultants are increasingly viewed as partners and as integrated actors within the client organization, contributing to ongoing organizing processes and knowledge creation.

This shift reflects a transition from a "come-and-go" model toward a more process-oriented approach, in which consultants become part of the client organization over time (Werr & Styhre, 2002). From this viewpoint, consultants may function as a form of organizational memory, as they often possess a longer temporal perspective than individual managers who frequently change roles or organizations (Werr & Styhre, 2002).

However, this transformation remains characterized by structural ambiguity. While the actual use of consultants for value creation tends to follow the logic of the network discourse, managerial efforts to preserve legitimacy often continue to reflect bureaucratic assumptions, emphasizing control, distance, and formal accountability (Werr & Styhre, 2002). This

coexistence of competing discourses highlights the inherently ambiguous nature of the client-consultant relationship in contemporary organizational contexts.

The evolution of consultant skills and the impact of digitalization

Beyond functional and industry-specific knowledge, the importance of soft skills has gained increasing attention in consulting, particularly in the area of talent development (Helens-Hart & Engstrom, 2020). Among these skills, empathy is identified as a core attribute for talent development consultants, understood as the ability to recognize and respond to the feelings, needs, and concerns of others (Helens-Hart & Engstrom, 2020). Empathy-related competencies include active listening, perspective taking, adaptation to the audience, and communication style, all of which are positively associated with consultant performance and the quality of professional relationships (Helens-Hart & Engstrom, 2020).

At the same time, digitalization has reshaped the skill requirements and operating models of consulting in specific niches, such as innovation finance consulting (Wattiez & Goy, 2023). Historically, this segment was characterized by low digital maturity, with a strong reliance on human expertise and highly personalized services, enabling high margins with relatively low investment levels (Wattiez & Goy, 2023). However, digital disruptors have emerged, challenging traditional models by offering fully digitalized, low-cost solutions, often based on subscription schemes rather than success fees, and leveraging software as a key resource to achieve economies of scale (Wattiez & Goy, 2023).

In response, established consulting firms have tended to pursue incremental adaptations to their business models, primarily through the digitalization of internal processes and the enhancement of their value propositions via supportive digital tools (Wattiez & Goy, 2023). In this context, technology is positioned as an enabler that facilitates task automation and knowledge capitalization, rather than as a substitute for the consultant's central role in analysis, strategic advisory, and innovation capabilities (Wattiez & Goy, 2023).

Reconfiguration of business models in the context of digitalization

Digitalization has reshaped business processes in such a way that organizational activities are now approached differently than in the past, signaling a significant shift in management practices (Brazo *et al.*, 2023). Traditionally, consulting business models focused on completing a defined set of tasks or delivering specific solutions (Wattiez & Goy, 2023). As noted by Mukerjee *et al.* (2023), the advance of digital transformation has shifted consulting revenue models toward outcome-oriented arrangements, as clients seek value-based arrangements rather than task-based engagements (Mukerjee *et al.*, 2023).

This outcome-based perspective is more holistic, emphasizing the tangible and strategic benefits that organizations obtain from the use of technology (Mukerjee *et al.*, 2023). As a result, consulting practices are progressively aligned with the need to connect strategic thinking with tactical execution, focusing on the value that the business ultimately derives from technological investments (Mukerjee *et al.*, 2023).

Evolution of value propositions and service delivery

Digital transformation induces changes in business models by automating processes, enabling consulting firms to save time and enhance their value propositions (Wattiez & Goy, 2023). Within the sector, Wattiez and Goy (2023) identify three main modes through which business models evolve under the influence of digitalization.

First, enriched solution shop models represent an enhancement of the traditional approach through the integration of digital tools that increase advisory effectiveness and enable more advanced forms of support, including participation in problem-solving activities and the co-development of prototypes in collaboration with clients (Wattiez & Goy, 2023). Second, value-added process business models increasingly rely on the use of algorithms to generate

competitive advantage, with digitalization becoming the core of the value proposition (Wattiez & Goy, 2023). Third, facilitated network models position consulting firms as orchestrators of innovation ecosystems composed of multiple actors, through which they provide specialized solutions and capabilities tailored to client-specific challenges (Wattiez & Goy, 2023).

Emergence of disruptive models in innovation finance consulting

In niches such as innovation finance consulting, where human expertise has historically played a dominant role (Wattiez & Goy, 2023), digital transformation has driven the emergence of disruptive actors that break with the traditional model (Wattiez & Goy, 2023). These new models focus on technology-based solutions, such as software platforms or dashboards, which clients can use autonomously and at relatively low cost (Wattiez & Goy, 2023). They seek to achieve economies of scale by handling higher volumes with fewer personnel and involving consultants only at critical stages of the process (Wattiez & Goy, 2023). An illustrative example is the adoption of subscription-based models rather than fixed success fees (Wattiez & Goy, 2023).

By contrast, established players often pursue incremental changes, relying on digital tools to improve internal efficiency and enrich their value propositions, for instance by offering dashboards or project monitoring systems, rather than fundamentally replacing the consultant's role (Wattiez & Goy, 2023).

Reconfiguration of key skills

As highlighted by Mukerjee *et al.* (2023), digital transformation and changes in business models have generated a critical need, with a strong emphasis on agility and continuous development (Mukerjee *et al.*, 2023).

As the boundaries between management consulting and information technology consulting are increasingly dissolved (Mukerjee *et al.*, 2023), the need has emerged for a new professional profile: the Business-Techno consultant (Mukerjee *et al.*, 2023). These professionals are required to possess a holistic understanding that encompasses several complementary skill domains (Mukerjee *et al.*, 2023).

From a technological perspective, they must be capable of designing solutions that leverage next-generation technologies such as cloud computing, machine learning and artificial intelligence (ML/AI), and the Internet of Things (IoT) (Mukerjee *et al.*, 2023). In parallel, they are expected to demonstrate strong domain and industry skills, reflected in a deep understanding of both industrial and functional contexts (Mukerjee *et al.*, 2023).

A strategic and financial orientation is also essential. Business-Techno consultants must be able to articulate and align business value, expected benefits, and return on investment (ROI) with proposed technological investments (Mukerjee *et al.*, 2023). This includes understanding how technology simplifies operations and how IT system consolidation can be used to reduce total cost of ownership (TCO) while safeguarding future investments (Mukerjee *et al.*, 2023). In addition, they are expected to engage in continuous evaluation of enterprise technology architecture (ETA) and operational processes in order to identify opportunities for automation and improvement (Mukerjee *et al.*, 2023).

Alongside these technical and strategic capabilities, collaborative and human skills have gained critical importance, particularly empathy, despite digital transformation being largely mediated by technology (Helens-Hart & Engstrom, 2020). Empathy is considered a defining competence for consultants, as it is associated with positive organizational outcomes such as effective leadership, high-quality interpersonal relationships, and superior performance (Helens-Hart & Engstrom, 2020).

According to Helens-Hart and Engstrom (2020), empathic practice is expressed through specific, developable components, including active listening to identify clients' feelings, needs, and concerns; perspective taking to understand audience expectations and motivations; audience adaptation, which involves tailoring content and complexity to client experience and

knowledge rather than offering “ready-made” solutions; and communication style, characterized by a conversational tone, dynamism, enthusiasm, and continuous checks for understanding in order to engage clients both emotionally and intellectually.

These evolving skill requirements are embedded within a broader transformation of the consulting environment, which is shifting from an ideal of bureaucratic organization, based on control, clearly delimited work, and distant relationships, to a network-based organization grounded in collaboration, knowledge specialization, and continuous adaptation (Werr & Styhre, 2002). This transition requires consultants to act as collaborative peers within a network discourse, even as normative frameworks and traditional managerial identities often remain anchored in bureaucratic assumptions emphasizing control and distance (Werr & Styhre, 2002).

Consequently, learning and development programs must be flexible and project-adapted, whether just-in-time or agile, in order to build distinctive capabilities that represent an amalgam of knowledge, skills, and experience (Mukerjee *et al.*, 2023).

Discussion

The evolution of management consulting reveals a trajectory that extends from a craft-based practice grounded in individual experience toward a more structured discipline that seeks to base its interventions on systematic knowledge and empirical evidence. This process mirrors a transition similar to that observed in fields such as accounting or strategic management, where professionalization emerged through methodological formalization, ethical standards, and academic consolidation (Clark & Fincham, 2002).

One of the key milestones in this transformation was the standardization of the consulting process. The model proposed by Kubr (2002), consisting of entry, diagnosis, planning, implementation, and evaluation phases, helped to clearly differentiate professional consulting practice from purely empirical advisory work. This structure not only organized the consultant’s work but also conceptualized consulting as a formal mechanism for organizational learning. However, this same standardization coexists with a set of tensions that continue to define the nature of the profession.

In particular, the consultant–client relationship maintains a structural ambiguity that has been widely documented. Werr and Styhre (2002) note that clients seek specialized knowledge from consultants that they themselves do not possess, while simultaneously needing to preserve legitimacy and control over decision-making. This creates a paradox in which collaboration is combined with the dynamics of supervision and caution. Such a balance helps explain why consulting, despite its growing professionalization, remains a practice-laden with symbolic negotiation. The value of consulting services depends not only on the models employed, but also on the consultant’s ability to construct meaning and generate trust within the organization.

This evolution has not been homogeneous across contexts. The work of Szeiner, Mura, Horbulák, Roberson, and Poor (2020) on the case of Slovakia illustrates how institutional processes, economic openness, and structural changes shape the development of consulting in different regions. The transition from a centralized system to a competitive market enabled the adoption of international standards and the emergence of local consulting firms, demonstrating that sector consolidation is driven not only by theoretical or methodological factors, but also by broader economic and sociopolitical transformations.

From a knowledge perspective, management consulting is now interpreted as a knowledge-intensive industry. This view positions consulting as a key agent in the transfer of innovation and the diffusion of organizational capabilities. The analysis by Levishchenko, Lavryk, and Riabenko (2021) confirms this role by showing that a significant proportion of European firms develop innovations in collaboration with consulting firms, and that such relationships are associated with improved performance. These findings reinforce the idea that the value of consulting arises from the combination of codified knowledge and tacit experience, a duality

also emphasized by [Werr and Stjernberg \(2003\)](#), who describe consulting firms as knowledge systems that integrate structured methodologies with experiential learning.

The emergence of the business-techno consultant profile described by [Mukerjee et al. \(2023\)](#) illustrates how the profession is incorporating new competencies that combine strategic thinking, technological knowledge, and the ability to translate digital tools into business value. In this sense, consulting becomes a space in which managerial expertise, data analytics, and emerging technologies converge, redefining modes of intervention and expanding opportunities for value co-creation.

Further conceptual support for understanding the integration between technology and consulting practice can be drawn from the work of [Breidbach and Maglio \(2016\)](#), who showed that digital platforms facilitate interaction among multiple actors and enable the collaborative creation of solutions. From this perspective, consulting can be interpreted as moving away from a strictly linear process toward a more sociosystemic configuration, in which clients, consultants, and technologies jointly participate in the design and implementation of organizational improvements. In this sense, technology emerges not merely as a methodological support, but as a constitutive element that increasingly shapes the configuration of consulting services.

Beyond performance outcomes, recent studies underline the growing society and institutional embeddedness of consulting activities. Contemporary research highlights how consulting increasingly intersects issues of inclusion, gender dynamics and social entrepreneurship, reinforcing its role as a knowledge-intensive service with broader socio-economic implications ([Medina-Vicent, 2025](#); [Silva, Del Toro, & Palacios, 2025](#)).

The study by [Helens-Hart and Engstrom \(2020\)](#) shows that empathy constitutes an indispensable element of consulting practice. Their analysis indicates that skills such as active listening, perspective taking, and client adaptation have a direct impact on the quality of interventions. This perspective aligns with [Schön's \(1983\)](#) notion of the reflective practitioner, which emphasizes that professional effectiveness is grounded in the capacity to reflect in action and to adapt performance to changing contexts. From this viewpoint, empathy emerges as a form of practical knowledge that strengthens consultant legitimacy and complements technical competencies.

Finally, epistemological challenges remain that constrain the consolidation of consulting as a fully established scientific discipline. Knowledge produced in this field tends to be contextual and highly dependent on client interactions, which limits its generalizability. At the same time, its legitimacy often rests on the ability to construct persuasive narratives of change and progress. Consequently, theoretical development in management consulting requires frameworks that recognize both the reflective dimension of practice and the importance of empirical evidence, an equilibrium that remains under construction.

Overall, the discussion suggests that management consulting has evolved into a dynamic knowledge system driven by the interaction between theory, professional practice, and technology. Its future consolidation will depend on the capacity to integrate these dimensions and to respond to emerging demands associated with digitalization, sustainability, and institutional change.

Despite the growing academic consolidation identified in this study, several structural limitations continue to shape the production of knowledge in management consulting research. First, the bibliometric evidence reveals a persistent geographical concentration of publications in countries of the Global North, particularly the United States and Western Europe. While this concentration reflects the historical development of the consulting industry and its academic institutionalization, it also suggests that dominant theoretical frameworks and professional models may insufficiently capture consulting practices in emerging, transitional, or non-Western contexts. As a result, important contextual variations in institutional environments, professional norms, and consulting roles may remain underexplored in the current literature.

In addition, the consolidation of management consulting as a scientific field continues to face epistemological challenges related to the contextual and practice-based nature of consulting knowledge. Much of the knowledge produced in this domain is embedded in

specific organizational settings and client–consultant interactions, which limits its generalizability and complicates cumulative theory building. While bibliometric analyses provide valuable insights into intellectual structures and thematic evolution, they cannot fully capture the tacit, relational, and processual dimensions that underpin consulting practice. This tension highlights the need for future research designs that combine large-scale quantitative mapping with qualitative, longitudinal, and context-sensitive approaches in order to deepen the understanding of how consulting knowledge is generated, legitimized, and transferred across organizational environments.

Conclusions

This study examined the long-term evolution and scientific consolidation of management consulting through a systematic review and bibliometric analysis spanning more than four decades. The findings reveal that management consulting has progressed from a predominantly practice-driven and experience-based activity toward a structured and differentiated field of knowledge characterized by increasing theoretical articulation, methodological formalization, and thematic diversification.

The bibliometric evidence demonstrates sustained growth in academic output, the emergence of identifiable intellectual cores, and the coexistence of consolidated research streams, specialized subdomains, and exploratory peripheral themes. This stratified configuration reflects not fragmentation, but disciplinary maturation. Management consulting research now exhibits a recognizable conceptual architecture anchored in digital transformation, organizational knowledge, project governance, and innovation.

At the same time, the results underscore a redefinition of the profession itself. Consulting is increasingly positioned as a knowledge-intensive intermediary that integrates strategic reasoning, technological capability, and relational intelligence. The field’s evolution suggests a transition toward hybrid forms of expertise in which digital infrastructures and human judgment coexist as complementary sources of value creation.

Despite this consolidation, important challenges remain. Knowledge production in management consulting continues to be highly contextual and embedded in client–consultant interactions, which complicates cumulative theory building. Future research will need to deepen the integration between large-scale quantitative mapping and context-sensitive qualitative inquiry in order to further clarify how consulting knowledge is generated, legitimized, and diffused across institutional environments.

Overall, the evidence presented confirms that management consulting has moved beyond its origins as a loosely defined advisory practice and has evolved into an institutionalized and dynamically evolving knowledge system. Its continued development will depend on its capacity to integrate technological innovation, methodological rigor, and reflective professional practice within an increasingly complex organizational landscape.

Practical and research implications

The findings of this study offer several implications for practice, research, and organizational decision-making. First, for management consultants, the results highlight the growing need to integrate technological competencies with strategic and relational skills. As consulting increasingly operates at the intersection of management and digital transformation, consultants are required not only to master emerging technologies but also to translate these tools into business value while maintaining strong interpersonal capabilities such as empathy, active listening, and adaptive communication. This suggests that professional development and training programs should move beyond purely technical upskilling and emphasize hybrid competence profiles that combine analytical, technological, and human-centered capabilities.

Second, for organizations and clients of consulting services, the study underscores the importance of viewing consulting engagements as collaborative knowledge-creation

processes rather than transactional service arrangements. The evolution toward outcome-oriented and digitally enabled consulting models implies that organizations should actively engage in co-creation dynamics, invest in internal absorptive capacity, and establish governance structures that support long-term learning and capability development rather than short-term problem solving.

Third, for educators and researchers, the results point to the need for academic programs and future research agendas that reflect the changing nature of consulting practice. Graduate education in management and consulting should incorporate interdisciplinary curricula that integrate management theory, digital technologies, and reflective practice. From a research perspective, future studies could address the contextual and geographical blind spots identified in the literature, particularly by expanding empirical research in underrepresented regions and by combining bibliometric approaches with qualitative and longitudinal designs to further explore how consulting knowledge is generated, validated, and transferred across organizational contexts.

Together, these implications reinforce the view of management consulting as an evolving knowledge-based profession whose effectiveness depends on the integration of technology, theory, and human judgment in increasingly complex organizational environments.

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